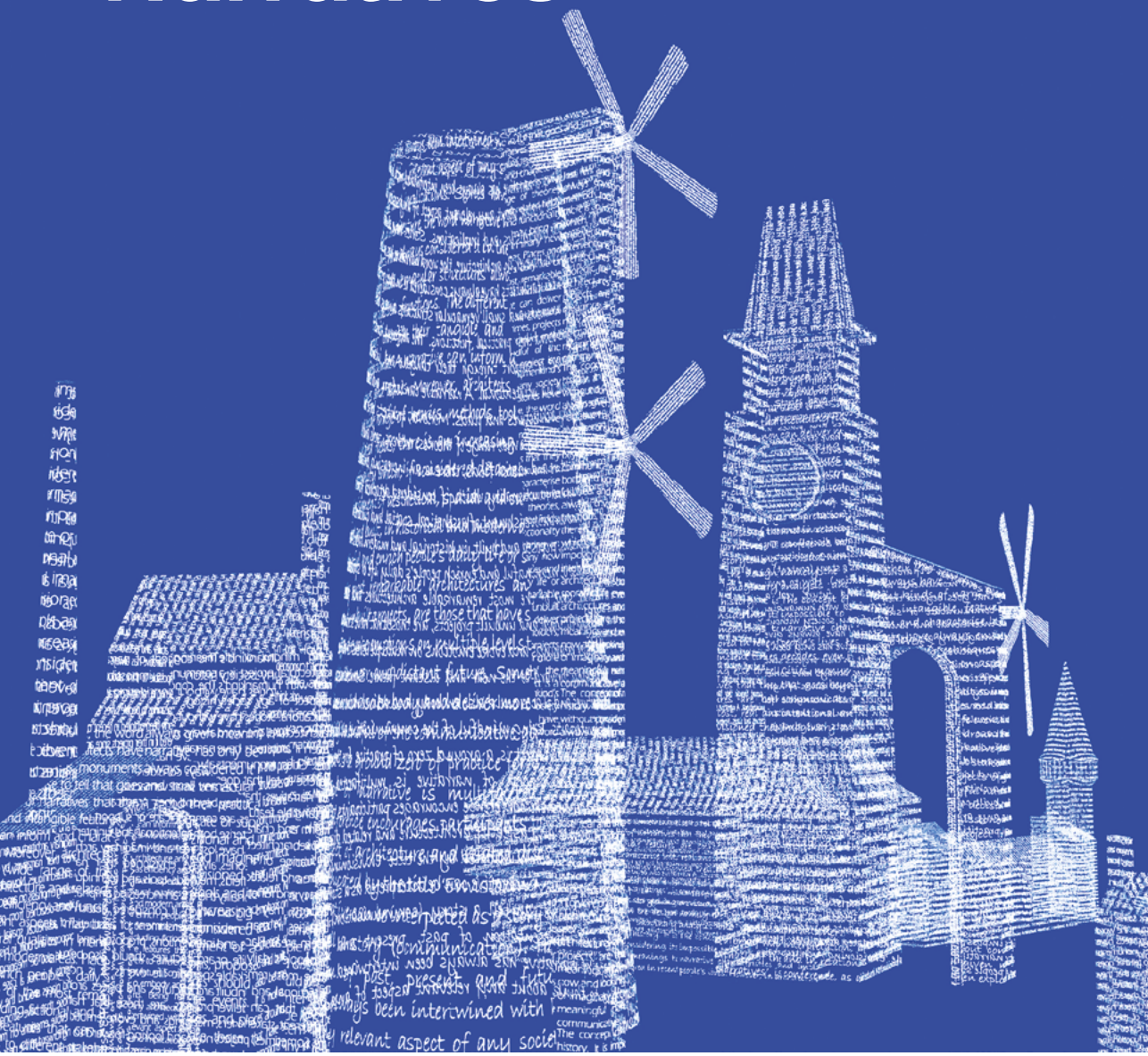
Envisioning Architectural Narratives



Edited by
Danilo Di Mascio

University of
HUDDERSFIELD
Inspiring global professionals

EAEA15

Monograph of the 15th Biennial International Conference of the European Architectural Envisioning Association

Huddersfield, United Kingdom, September 1-3, 2021

ENVISIONING ARCHITECTURAL NARRATIVES

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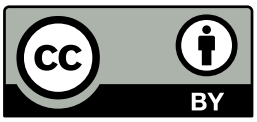
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Barley Hall: new narratives for an old building

Introduction

Since 2018 York Archaeological Trust (YAT) has been working with specialists at the University of Huddersfield to assess the interpretative offer at Barley Hall, its reconstructed medieval townhouse attraction. A project team of three looked at how the narrative presented to visitors deals with one period in the building's early history: its time as a residence for the canons of Nostell Priory.

The project has applied and interpreted the concept of 'narrative' in two ways: in relation to the canons and their lives as individuals and members of a community; and in terms of the narrative qualities of the architecture of their residence, by which the structure is interpreted through its tangible and intangible features (including its materials, constructive system, spaces, decorations, colours, lights, shadows, etc.), giving rise to meanings, information, and evoked emotions (Di Mascio and Maver 2014).

A sister attraction of the world-famous JORVIK Viking Centre, Barley Hall belongs to the JORVIK Group of attractions in the historic city of York, and first opened to the public in 1993. Prior to the coronavirus pandemic it attracted around 30,000 visitors per annum. Ambitious plans developed in the run-up to its launch envisaged Barley Hall as a 'living history' venue, which would consolidate YAT's reputation for innovative approaches to heritage interpretation, as exemplified at its two existing attractions, JORVIK and the Archaeological Resource Centre. JORVIK in particular was at that stage a by-word for highly speculative evocations of historic environments (Tuckley 2020: 78-84), with its life-size reconstruction of a 10th-century urban landscape featuring detailed mannequins, an ambient soundtrack and synthetic smells, all based on archaeological evidence from the Coppergate dig of 1976-81 (with other sorts of evidence adduced for further context and detail). For Barley Hall the plan was 'to re-create a living and working medieval household, carrying on its ever-varying daily round through seasonal feasts and fasts'(Kightly 1991: 37).

Budgetary constraints meant that this vision was never fully realised, although Barley Hall was launched with five rooms fully furnished to appear as they might have *c*. 1483, when the locally important Snawsell family was in residence; in its first years of operation an audio tour guided visitors from room to room, with dramatic monologues by well-known actors portraying the household members. Latterly, Barley Hall has fulfilled a range of additional functions, including as a

venue for public events and for private hire; it currently plays host to temporary exhibitions which occupy the upper stage of its gallery and chamber ranges (the *Magic and Mystery* exhibition, which looks at magical belief and practices in medieval England, has been in place since summer 2018, its original run having been extended indefinitely due to the coronavirus pandemic). This blend of uses creates a layering of narrative and representation at Barley Hall, which has never yet been considered in detail.

The present project brought together a representative of YAT's Interpretation and Engagement department and lecturers in architecture and medieval history from the University of Huddersfield to look at an early phase in the building's poorly documented past; the period after its construction as a townhouse for the canons of Nostell Priory. Nostell was a house of regular canons (also sometimes known as 'Augustinian', 'Austin' or 'black' canons); men (ordained priests) living in a religious community under a rule. The numbers of regular canons in England grew in the course of the 12th century, and Nostell was one of the order's first English houses (its earliest in Yorkshire). At points in its history Nostell seems to have been very wealthy; *c*. 1250 it came into the possession of a parcel of land off Stonegate in central York, near York Minster, in connection with the priors' role as canons prebendary, which required them to be in attendance at the Minster at various times (Greenway 1999). Dendrochronological dating of the earliest timbers at Barley Hall has established a date of *c*. 1361 for the construction of a timber-framed 'hospicium' in a prestigious location alongside other prebendal houses, some of which are represented by medieval fabric in existing properties elsewhere on Stonegate (Kightly 1999: 4). At other times in its history, however, Nostell ran up severe debts, and by the middle years of the 15th century it was letting the hall out to a series of tenants. In 1540 Nostell Priory was dissolved in Henry VIII's Dissolution of the Monasteries, and all of its property passed to the crown. The history of the building between that date and the closing decades of the 20th century still awaits detailed research, and is mentioned only in passing in existing interpretative materials.

This project (with the working title *How do we tell the story of the canons regular of Nostell priory at Barley Hall?*) has seen an audit of existing interpretative resources, a questionnaire and focus groups with Barley Hall staff and volunteers, and a number of experiments with visualisation techniques. In addition, three comparable sites in Yorkshire have been visited by the project team. The aim of the project has been to investigate how the interpretative offer at Barley Hall might be enhanced by bringing this period in the building's history more fully to the attention of its visitors and custodians, and to establish which interpretative methods would be most successful in achieving this end; in addition, whether a combination of visualisation techniques can successfully communicate an authentic, meaningful and appealing narrative on the canons during their time at Barley Hall, to convey something of their activities and motivations to the various audiences that spend time there. The desirability of selecting this historical moment in the building's history for enhanced representation to visitors remains a

moot point; audience-focused research might help to determine levels of interest and knowledge with respect to medieval religious orders and their households.

Existing resources on the canons for use by visitors are scarce, and the narrative presented via the dressed interiors, information panels and guidebook relates overwhelmingly to the late 15th century, when the canons had already left for good, and to the efforts by YAT to reconstruct the hall in the 1980s and 90s. Focus groups and questionnaires have demonstrated that there is a general lack of awareness and understanding (amongst staff and, by extension, amongst Barley Hall volunteers and visitors too) around who the canons were, what they did, and why they needed a high-status dwelling in the city centre. While this is not necessarily a problem in terms of visitor enjoyment of the site or YAT's mission as an educational charity, it presents an opportunity to tell a new story about the building in innovative and experimental ways, refreshing an interpretative offer that might otherwise stagnate. Barley Hall's temporary exhibitions and a seasonal events programme currently do the job of creating variety at the hall to encourage repeat visits, but this project has suggested the potential for enhancing the 'core narrative' of the *in situ* interpretation.

The fullest account of the canons that has been made available thus far at Barley Hall is the 1999 edition of the guidebook by Charles Kightly, roughly a quarter of which is taken up with a discussion of the hall's beginnings as a monastic town house (Kightly 1999). Kightly had been commissioned by YAT in 1992 to research the hall for the purposes of recreating its interiors (Kightly Interiors n.d.), and his guidebook, although out of print, remains the foundational text in interpreting the hall for visitors. There is much unsifted material in the YAT archives, including unpublished architectural plans, archaeological 'grey literature', and a great deal of documentation relating to its development as a visitor attraction and its first decade of operation.

Since the appearance in print of Kightly's guidebook there have been a number of developments with the potential to improve our understanding of the earliest history of Barley Hall and its residents, and to interpret it for non-specialist audiences. An edition of Nostell Priory's 12th – 15th-century cartulary is now available (Frost 2005); there has been a major academic publication on the regular canons in Britain (with two chapters dealing specifically with the situation in northern England / Yorkshire) (Burton and Stöber 2011); YAT commissioned a scoping exercise to examine the small finds from the three archaeological interventions in Coffee Yard (the small square where Barley Hall stands) which took place between 1987 and 1991, and in 2017 produced an evaluation and building recording report on 1 Coffee Yard (which stands directly opposite Barley Hall, occupying what may have been the site of one of the wings of the canons' residence) (Kendall and Loffman 2017); the *British Historic Towns Atlas* series published its York edition in 2017, with commentary on the arrangement of prebendal properties in the vicinity of York Minster (Addyman 2017); and 2019 saw the advent of *The Northern Way*, a project to complete a searchable online

index of all primary sources on the political activity of the archbishops of York in the period 1304 – 1405 in diocesan archives (York Archbishops' Registers Revealed 2016). The Borthwick Institute has also greatly expanded its online ordination lists for York clergy, including four edited by David M. Smith for the roughly 100-year period under consideration (Borthwick Institute 2021).

Yorkshire's medieval religious houses as heritage sites

In the same period, however, there has been little meaningful work to analyse and evaluate the interpretation of medieval religious houses as heritage sites and tourism destinations; questions around narrative, representation, access, diversity and ethics have been addressed more fully in reference to conventional museum exhibition spaces. Yet the sites of religious houses in the care of heritage organisations in the UK play host to a range of interpretative materials in a variety of media; by dint of the ruined or greatly altered state of the buildings (and the fragmentary nature of the documentary evidence relating to them) the interpretation often relies upon visualisations of the houses as they once appeared, with representations of the sorts of activities supposed to have taken place in them at a given moment in the past, carried out by the sorts of people who are supposed to have lived and worked in them.

The Centre for the Study of Christianity and Culture at the University of York, for instance, has a track record of more than ten years in creating innovative resources to interpret medieval religious sites for non-specialist audiences. Its Micklegate Priory Revealed project includes 3D visualisations of Holy Trinity, Micklegate, York (about fifteen minutes' walk from Barley Hall), as it might have appeared in the 15th century, when it was home to a community of Benedictine monks (Centre for the Study of Christianity and Culture 2013). Its partnership with Hexham Abbey (whose priors, like those of Nostell, were canons prebendary of York Minster), too, produced 3D visualisations of this medieval house of regular canons (Centre for the Study of Christianity and Culture 2014). Both examples feature populated scenes, and the Holy Trinity resource includes an extramural view of Micklegate, inhabited by a range of secular figures and livestock, further contextualising the church and its community within the wider cityscape.

In the first half of 2019 the project team visited three former houses of regular canons in Yorkshire, to compare and contrast their resources for telling the stories of their respective communities. At Nostell Priory, now an 18th-century house in the care of the National Trust with no standing medieval fabric (with the exception of a much-altered farm building nearby), a single panel in the stable block deals with its medieval history. There is a little more information available in temporary, pull-up panels at the 16th-century parish church of St Michael and Our Lady, Wragby, which has historic links with the priory and whose churchyard adjoins the site.

The nave of Bridlington Priory was the only portion of the canons' church to survive the Dissolution, and it now stands as a spectacular example of late

medieval architecture that continues in use for worship. Amongst its several exhibits on its architecture and history it has a series of pull-up panels; one of these outlines the duties of a canon, and another two deal with the life of St John of Bridlington (*d*. 1379), the celebrated prior who was canonised in 1404 (Scully 1912). In addition, there is a case with a mannequin clothed in the garb of a regular canon (a box nearby contains a child-sized version of the same to encourage dressing up), plus an activity box inviting youngsters to 'make an illuminated letter, a pilgrim badge or a picture of St John of Bridlington', with accompanying text explaining how the canons copied religious books by hand, and how pilgrims to the shrine of St John at the priory wore distinctive 'B' shaped badges. The priory also displays a tapestry, completed in 1996 (Bridlington Priory 2019); the first seven of its twelve panels depict episodes or subjects relating to its history before the Dissolution, with some featuring named individual canons.

The fragmentary standing remains of Kirkham Priory have been provided by English Heritage with a range of in situ, printed and online resources designed to evoke the priory in its heyday, as a living and working environment, including a set of illustrations of priory buildings featuring the canons and their servants (English Heritage n.d.). The emphasis is on architectural detail and institutional history, including the formal arrangements governing the daily lives of regular canons at Kirkham and elsewhere, with some additional information on noteworthy individuals or events. A set of resources designed for use by school groups was available on site in summer 2019: the 'Walter's Story Abbey Box', which could be booked in advance, had replica objects and a series of letters to encourage learners to investigate the life of a fictional medieval monk, duplicating a resource also available at Byland, Rievaulx and Roche abbeys (all Cistercian foundations, rather than houses of canons).

Representation of selected architectural elements for new narratives

Having considered the approaches to narrative and visualisation at these three sites, each so different from the other and from Barley Hall, the project team experimented with visualisations of the Nostell canons' built environment in York, insofar as it can be reconstructed with reference to the local archaeological record, historical sources, and the drawings produced by the architects responsible for the reconstruction of this timber-framed structure in the 1990s. A history of the structure prior to its restoration under the direction of the architects Russell and Paula Wright appeared in YAT's *Interim* publication in spring 1987, coinciding with one of its several investigations of the property:

> The building comprises a mid-14th-century timber-framed building running back from Stonegate towards Grape Lane, with its rearmost four bays surviving, although it has been shortened at its Stonegate end. This building was originally of a three-storey construction with a two-bay, two-storey great chamber or solar in the third and fourth bays. […] In the 15th century a new hall building was built across the site at right-angles to the earlier building

> and joined into its south-west face. A dais was constructed for this hall by breaking through the wall of the earlier building and creating a recess which was screened off probably by a partition wall. […] Additions in the late 16th or early 17th century extended the width of this building toward Grape Lane. Extensive alteration of the earlier building, which had passed into the hands of a lay tenant in the late 15th century, also took place probably in the mid-16th century and involved the removal of the top storey and the lowering of the crown-post roof trusses to create a two-storey building. Further alterations in the 17th century involved the partial rebuilding of a third storey and the establishment of a right-of-way through the screens passage of the 15th-century hall building […] (Stockwell 1987: 38-39)

The project team settled on the chamber range at Barley Hall as the part of the building with most potential: it is the earliest part of the structure, built with timbers felled in *c*. 1361. A brief account of its reconstruction is given in the guidebook:

> Like most mediaeval timber buildings, the still more complex structure of the 14th-century Chamber Range was prefabricated off-site. First the surviving original timbers were dis-assembled and taken to Peter McCurdy's yard […]. There re-usable sections of ancient timber were 'scarf-jointed' to new wood where necessary. New framing elements were constructed to replace rotten or missing originals. Then large sections of the frame were re-assembled flat and kept damp to prevent drying-out before their return to York in early 1992. […] they were laboriously manoeuvred along narrow Coffee Yard and re-assembled in the Barley Hall courtyard. (Kightly 1999: 16-17)

Within this range, the team focused on the Great Chamber (Fig. 01), currently in use as a museum gallery. Unlike other spaces in Barley Hall, it has never been dressed.

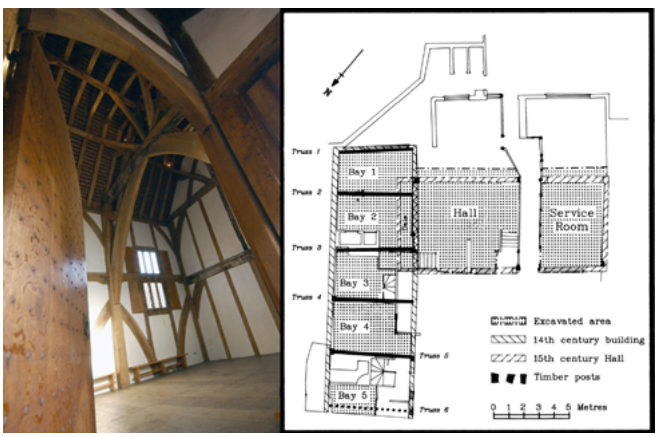


Fig. 01. Left: view of the Great Chamber from the external staircase. Right: ground-floor plan of Barley Hall showing area of excavation by YAT in 1987. Reproduced from Stockwell 1985: 40.

Source: image copyright York Archaeological Trust.

A focus group held with Barley Hall staff and volunteers at the YAT offices in November 2018 suggested that the interpretative resources currently available to Barley Hall's lay audiences, in particular the orthographic projections (plan views, elevations and sections, which can be found in display panels and in the current Barley Hall guidebook) are not easy to read without accompanying explanatory materials. For the focus group, a simple combination of the existing ground-floor plan view and a vertical section, with the introduction of a scaled silhouette of a person, enhanced the comprehension of spaces and dimensions. 3D representations such as axonometric views and perspective images suggested potential to the group to communicate some architectural features in an even more successful way.

With these reflections in mind, it was decided to explore the use of analytical drawings to highlight aspects that are usually overlooked by visitors and consequently let them discover, understand and appreciate them. Analytical drawings are more diagrammatic representations that show only selected elements of a building. In this way, the viewer is not distracted by overabundant or unnecessary details.

Kightly explains that medieval 'chambers' were used as both bedrooms and parlours, and that the Barley Hall Great Chamber would have been no exception. The suggestion is that the prior would have used this room as a welcoming space for visitors or important work-related meetings.

> Such visitors, conducted directly into the Great Chamber via the stairway from the courtyard, would doubtless have been impressed by the height of the room and the stylish 'crown-post truss' construction of its roof – and thus by the wealth and status of its owners. (Kightly 1999: 8)

In Kightly's description, the Great Chamber and its architectural features have narrative qualities because they communicate specific meanings to visitors and trigger emotions. This new set of analytical representations focuses on three selected aspects: space and movement; timber-framed structure; and basic light sources and shadows (to convey something of atmosphere). Kightly's account emphasises the potential significance of these three interconnected aspects, as well as the connection between the narrative of the canons' daily life and the narrative features of the tangible and intangible elements of architecture.

The set of analytical drawings identifies and highlights these narrative elements, and they can be considered new visual narratives in themselves. The existing documentation within the YAT archive relating to the structure of the chamber was used as the main reference; the archive currently lacks a consistent set of orthographic projections relating to the structure of the chamber, and analysis and interpretation of the very varied materials available highlighted some discrepancies. The orthographic projections were imported and redrawn in a CAD software where they were also compared through the use of construction lines. The new set of digital drawings then constituted the base to produce the

various 3D models used to create the analytical representations. The first set of images highlights the two main paths across Coffee Yard towards the Great Chamber. Some of the images show bird's-eye views, while others use the first-person point of view. (Fig. 02)

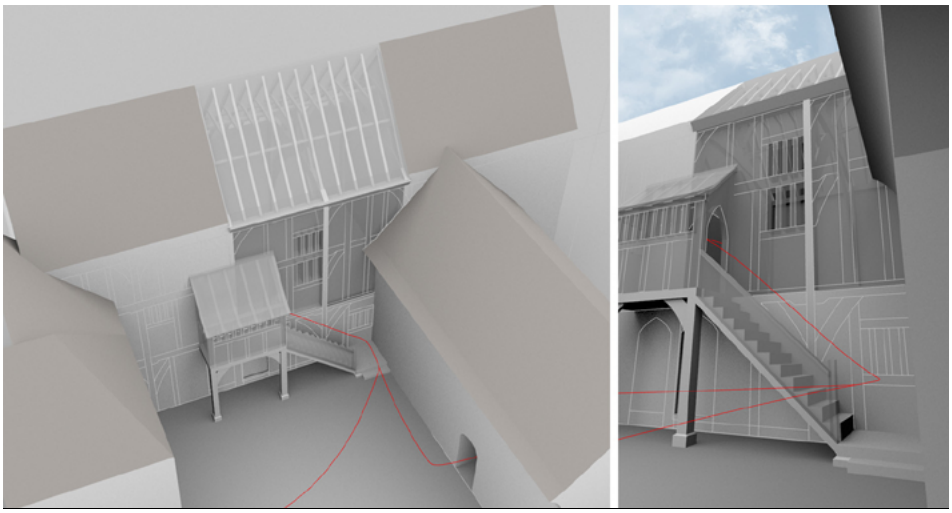


Fig. 02. The two main paths across Coffee Yard towards the Great Chamber.

Source: authors' personal archive.

The second set of images isolates the timber-framed structure of the Great Chamber, and it emphasizes the shape, size and aesthetical and constructive complexity, which includes the already mentioned crown-post truss. (Fig. 03) The last set of analytical representations is constituted by internal views of the Great Chamber illuminated by a few lighting sources in order to emphasize the atmosphere of this space.

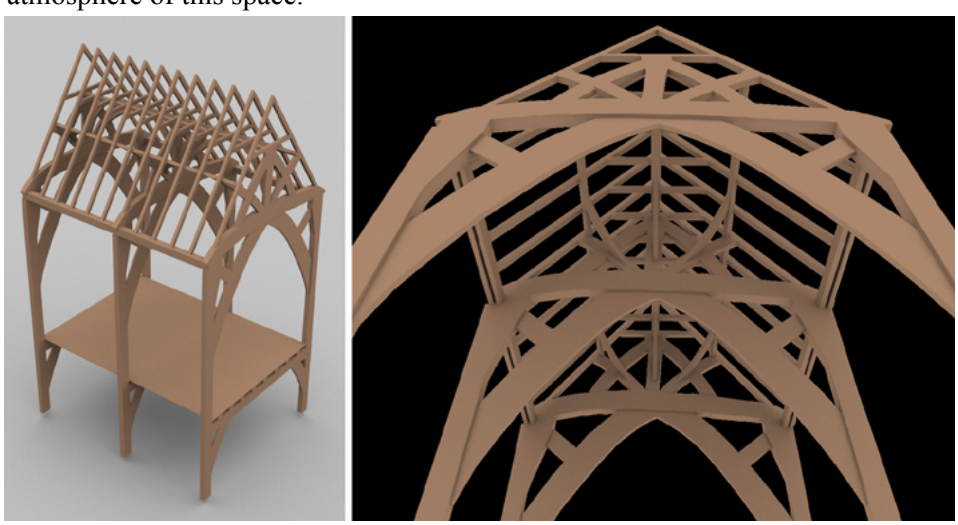


Fig. 03. Images of the timber-framed structure of the Great Chamber.

Source: authors' personal archive.

As the project progressed, an opportunity arose to involve a final-year BA (Hons) Modelmaking student at Arts University Bournemouth. The brief to the student was that his model (which would be submitted for assessment in fulfilment of the requirements of his degree) should help us to address questions of movement (inside the room, as well as into / out of the room via the external staircase) and the placement of non-structural elements (such as furniture, apparatus for lighting and heating etc.) within the chamber, as part of our efforts to imagine the various functions to which the Great Chamber would have been put (both formal and informal). The model was intended to be experimental rather than strictly reconstructive in nature (Fig. 04), given the lack of detailed evidence for medieval interiors of this kind, but representing accurately the dimensions of the chamber and of any potential fixtures and fittings appropriate to the period (Morgan 2017).



Fig. 04. The dressed interior of the Great Chamber. Model by Arthur Fleetham.

Source: image copyright the artist.

Conclusions and future plans

The project originally envisaged a resource pack for staff and volunteers as an outcome, with the possibility of sharing it with the other operators of similar historic sites. The challenges presented by the anti-coronavirus measures of 2020/21, however, have put a different complexion on matters. Barley Hall reopened to visitors after the first lockdown in July 2020, operating a 'socially distanced' model for visitors, with a one-way route around the attraction and some areas made off-limits, and numbers of volunteers and staff kept to a minimum. It underwent two periods of closure again in 2020 and 2021, in common with other JORVIK Group attractions, and reopened with restrictions in May 2021. In circumstances such as these, novel approaches to visualisation, representation and narrative become more urgent. At the time of writing, no decisions have been

taken as to how to present the new models of the Great Chamber to Barley Hall's stakeholders, but their potential at a time of limited access is clear, when heritage organisations are increasingly pivoting to events and exhibitions in the digital realm.

Our questions around the application of narrative and affect remain largely unanswered. Crucially, the representations remain unpopulated and static. The other sites that have been visited have offered little in terms of guidance for how stories at a human (rather than an institutional) level might inform the narratives available to audiences; the residents of houses of regular canons, when pictured, are generally seen at a distance, as generic male religious, although exceptions do occur, as in the named figures depicted in the Bridlington Priory tapestries, or those that animate the reconstructions of Micklegate Priory and Hexham Abbey, or when visitors are able to dress up and inhabit the role of a canon for themselves. The problem of who to represent, and how to represent them, is largely sidestepped when the canons are kept at arm's length, as anonymous operators within a community.

The challenges inherent in bringing the canons to life at Barley Hall are in large part related to the remoteness of the medieval period, in both chronological and cultural terms, and a general lack of awareness of medieval monastic culture and the experiences of its adherents. Bridging this gap via inspirational and affective interpretation will be key to representing the canons and telling their story. Our principal asset in this is the building, with its inherent narrative qualities, but its incompleteness as a structure contemporary with the period under consideration remains a problem, aggravated by the absence of an established sequence for the major structural changes it has undergone. The models developed in the course of this project, however, can act as a spur to further discussion and consultation, to inform the future of interpretative approaches at Barley Hall and elsewhere in the JORVIK Group attractions.

Acknowledgements

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Danilo Di Mascio *Editor*

Envisioning Architectural Narratives

This monograph documents the 15th European Architectural Envisioning Association Conference, entitled 'Envisioning Architectural Narratives', hosted (virtually) by the Department of Architecture and 3D Design, School of Art Design and Architecture, The University of Huddersfield, United Kingdom, from the 1st to the 3rd of September 2021. The event has continued the mission of the European Architectural Envisioning Association, namely, to create a valuable opportunity for communication and exchange of ideas and experiences in teaching, research and practice, with a particular focus, for this 15th edition, on envisioning the multiple and multifaceted relationships and applications between architecture and narrative. By considering the importance of narrative in humankind's history, the theme has invited participants to reflect upon three main topics: narrative and analysis, narrative and design, and narrative and representation.

This publication presents the papers accepted after two double-blind peer review processes. Each submission was assessed by three reviewers from the EAEA15 International Scientific Review committee, which is constituted by scholars from 12 countries. The authors of the accepted papers are from 20 different countries worldwide.

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